

A NEW WRITING OF JOACHIM OF FIORE: PRELIMINARY OBSERVATIONS

by STEPHEN WESSLEY

WITHIN the last decade noteworthy efforts have been made to provide for a better understanding of Joachim of Fiore through new editions of his work and the establishment of a more exact chronology for the events in his life. Under the direction of Kurt-Victor Selge a *Herausgeberkommission der kritischen Gesamtausgabe der Werke Joachims von Fiore* has been established, a symposium on the manuscript traditions of Joachim's work has been held under its auspices, and new critical editions are expected to be forthcoming soon. Professor Selge has contributed significantly to these efforts with his study of the chronology of Joachim's writings and his edition of the *Praephatio sive Prologus super Apocalypsim*.¹ I am building on this work and, of course, the outstanding work of such scholars as Marjorie Reeves, and hope now to identify a distinctive stage in Joachim of Fiore's career.

When Abbot Joachim wrote in his *Expositio in Apocalypsim* about his noted Easter eve vision, he asserted that he had received an insight into the plenitude of the Book of Revelation and the entire, *tota*, concordance of the Old and New Testaments.² He marked this 'revelatio' as the significant turning point in his understanding of John's Apocalypse. His 'revelatio' opened the closed door that had blocked his progress for a year on this exegesis and was an event that made him more bold to write.³ Similarly, in his *Psalterium decem chordarum* Joachim wrote about a vision at Pentecost of a ten-stringed psalter that showed him the mystery of the Trinity and served as the source of inspiration for the book

¹ Kurt-Victor Selge, 'L'origine delle opere di Gioacchino da Fiore', *L'attesa della fine dei tempi nel Medioevo* (Bologna, 1990), pp. 87–131; and 'Eine Einführung Joachims von Fiore in die Johannesapokalypse', *Deutsches Archiv für Erforschung des Mittelalters* 46 (1990), pp. 85–131, edition on pp. 102–31.

² Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio in Apocalypsim* (Venice, 1527; repr. Frankfurt a. M., 1964), fol. 39v: '... subito mihi meditantī aliquid quadam mentis oculis intelligentie claritate percepta de plenitudine libri huius et tota veteris ac novi testamenti concordia. Revelatio facta est. ...'

³ Ibid., fo. 39r–v, 'Aliquid in libro isto meditantī occurrere pro quo confisus de dono Dei audacior factus sum ad scribendum. Quinimmo in silencio et non scribendo timidior, ne quando tacenti mihi diceretur a iudice. Serve male et piger sciebas quia meto ubi non seminavi, et congrego ubi non sparsi. Oportuit ergo te committere pecuniam meam nummulariis et veniens recepissem utique quod meum est, cum usura.'

itself.⁴ In describing his visions Joachim acknowledges two major stages in his intellectual development. Joachim's visions, generally dated between 1183 and 1185,⁵ have received renewed attention in the last few years. In one article Robert Lerner stressed the significance of the Easter eve vision for Joachim's pivotal understanding of Revelation 'as a continuous story which revealed the entire history of the Church' and a period of earthly bliss. According to Lerner, this was a breakthrough for Joachim and was one of Joachim's three 'big ideas'; the other two were the concordance of Scripture and the Trinitarian scheme of history. In his discussion of Joachim's overall development Lerner went on to propose that, with Joachim's penchant for threes, something was missing. Since the Pentecost vision supporting a Trinitarian plan is connected with the Holy Spirit and the *Psalterium decem chordarum*, and the Easter eve vision supporting Joachim's reading of Revelation as a continuous story, the history of the Church, is connected to Christ and the *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, Lerner observed, 'The symmetry is almost too neat and falls short of perfection only in the lack of a "patrological" vision . . . inspiring the *Book of Concord* . . .'.⁶

The Pentecost vision and the Easter vision, dated between 1183 and 1185, are regarded by historians as symbols of Joachim's intellectual development and understood by Joachim to be heavenly validation that also inspired in him the confidence to write about his new insights into Scripture. But what had spurred on Joachim's earlier exegetical enterprise? Joachim confessed to working on an interpretation of Revelation before his Easter vision⁷ and although he wrote his main texts when visiting the

⁴ Joachim of Fiore, *Psalterium decem chordarum* (Venice, 1527; repr. Frankfurt a. M., 1965), fo. 227r-v.

⁵ For arguments for specific and differing chronologies see Robert Lerner, 'Joachim of Fiore's breakthrough to chiliasm', *Cristianesimo nella storia*, 6 (1985), pp. 489-512, in particular pp. 495-6; Bernard McGinn, *The Calabrian Abbot* (New York, 1985), p. 22; and Kurt-Victor Selge, 'L'origine', pp. 108-13.

⁶ Lerner, 'Joachim of Fiore's breakthrough to chiliasm', p. 502.

⁷ Ibid., pp. 496-8; Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, fo. 39r-v. Apparently Joachim worked on his texts over a long period; see Kurt-Victor Selge, 'L'origine', pp. 87-131 for a description of this. At the end of his life Joachim was concerned that the exemplars be safeguarded: 'Rogo ex parte dei omnipotentis coabbates meos et priores et ceteros fratres metuentes dominum et ea qua posse uideor auctoritate precipio, quatinus presens scriptum aut exemplar habentes secum ac si pro testamento opuscula que hactenus confecisse uideor et si quid me de nouo usque ad diem obitus mei contigerit scriptitare quamcunq; poterint collecta omnia, relictis in salua custodia exemplaribus, apostolico examini representent recipientes ab eadem sede uice mea correctionem . . .' in *Abbot Joachim of Fiore: Liber de Concordia Noui ac Veteris Testamenti*, ed. E. R. Daniel, *Transactions of the American Philosophical*

A New Writing of Joachim of Fiore

Cistercian house at Casamari from early 1183 to late 1184, he had been very busy with analysing Scripture before that period. For this early activity we have as a source the *Vita* of Abbot Joachim written, it is argued by Herbert Grundmann, by a Florentian after Joachim's death (1202), but no later than 1209.⁸ If we follow the sequence of events in this *Vita* of Abbot Joachim, it is clear that before Joachim journeyed to Casamari, where he was to have his two famous visions, he had earlier worked single-mindedly on the study of Scripture. As new abbot of the monastery of Corazzo (shortly before 1177) Joachim began as a faithful and prudent manager. After Joachim was elected abbot, the anonymous writer reports, 'A faithful and prudent man, he thus began to dispense the temporal substance faithfully and prudently, but all his prudence turned in the exercise of spiritual growth, not at all did he wish to neglect the grace which he received; but he thought, spoke and commented on the understanding of Scripture that was given to him.'⁹ Because it is evident to us from the anonymous text that the two visions mentioned above come later, we need to ask what was the source of Joachim's inspiration to which the anonymous writer referred, i.e. 'the understanding of Scripture that was given to him'.

From the period before 1177 Joachim is commenting on Scripture because he did not wish to neglect the grace he had received in the understanding of Scripture given to him, and he wanted to teach others what had been revealed to him. When and where did Joachim receive this grace or insight? If as outlined at the start of this paper the genesis of his two other 'big ideas' are represented as revelations given to him, what about

Society, 73, 8 (Philadelphia, 1983), p. 5. The process of manuscript transmission and, in particular, the correction of the Fiore manuscripts have been studied by Fabio Troncarelli and a detailed article with emphasis on Padua, Biblioteca Antoniana, MS 322, is soon to be published by him. Also, seldom mentioned in regard to the Fiore manuscripts is possible damage from the fire of 1215 that burned the original monastery founded by Joachim and that preceded the move of the Florentians to the present-day site of San Giovanni in Fiore. Unless it was symbolic, as a needed purification after the 1215 condemnation, did the fire result in any damage to their manuscripts and thus produce a possible immediate need for new and quickly produced copies such as Padua, Biblioteca Antoniana, MS 322?

⁸ Herbert Grundmann, 'Zur Biographie Joachims von Fiore und Rainers von Ponza', *Ausgewählte Aufsätze, II, Joachim von Fiore* (Stuttgart, 1977), pp. 281-94, esp. pp. 281-2, 293-4, and 297.

⁹ The anonymous *Vita*, in Grundmann, 'Zur Biographie Joachims von Fiore und Rainers von Ponza', pp. 345-6, 'Cepit itaque vir fidelis et prudens prudenter et fideliter temporalem substantiam dispensare, sed omnis prudentia eius in spiritualis profectus exercitio versabatur, nullatenus negligere volens gratiam quam acceperat; sed meditabatur, eloquebatur et commentabatur in data sibi desuper intelligentia scripturarum. . . .'

the genesis of his first 'big idea'—his understanding of the concordance of Scripture? Was this the result of a separate and distinctive revelation? The anonymous biographer, who also mentions the Easter and Pentecost visions, provides an answer when we read his text with this question in mind. The anonymous biography of Joachim, as we have it, opens with Joachim's pilgrimage in the Holy Land.¹⁰ The Florentine biographer begins with the announcement: 'Our Moses having received the revelation of the two-fold law descended from the mountain.'¹¹ Receiving the revelation of the two-fold law like a Moses is, for the anonymous biographer, the impetus for Joachim's spiritual odyssey. Thus Joachim is credited with receiving three 'revelations': the Pentecost vision connected to the Holy Spirit, the Easter vision connected to Christ, the Son, and this Mosaic vision of the two-fold law connected to God the Father.¹² Even the wording of the later Easter vision suggests a pattern that includes an earlier vision of a concordance of Scripture. When Robert Lerner studied the Easter vision he asked why did Joachim word his description of his Easter vision such that it was purported to reveal the plenitude of the Book of Revelation and the *entire*, 'tota', concordance of Scripture. It can be seen now that this word 'tota' was necessary because Joachim had long before been exploring and writing about the basic two-fold concordance of Scripture that had been revealed to him in a Mosaic fashion on the mount at the beginning of his journey.

What was the content and form of his Mosaic vision? In Book Two of his *Liber concordie* Joachim speaks about having been shown a vision of the special connection of the two Testaments on a mountain top. Comparing himself to Moses receiving the Ten Commandments on the mount, Joachim claimed he himself through the gift of grace saw the relationship of the two Testaments on the top of the mountain.¹³ (Here it should be

¹⁰ Grundmann argued that the anonymous *Vita* has survived only in part; the first and last parts are missing. See Grundmann, 'Zur Biographie Joachims von Fiore und Rainers von Ponza', pp. 292–4.

¹¹ The anonymous *Vita* in *ibid.*, p. 342, 'Moises noster gemine revelatione legis accepta de monte descendit'

¹² To see Joachim's intellectual development in terms of these three visions, each connected to one of the three persons of the Trinity, is to understand Joachim according to the programme he and his biographer put forth. These visions can be seen also to have occurred in Trinitarian sequence if one accepts Robert Lerner's dating of the visions in 'Joachim of Fiore's breakthrough to chiliasm', pp. 492–6 and 508.

¹³ *Abbot Joachim of Fiore: Liber de Concordia Novi ac Veteris Testamenti*, pp. 145–6, 'Has, inquam, duas arbores sublimes et condensas ponamus ante oculos mentis, et sic in eis Patrem et Filium, quorum alius ex alio est principaliter intelligamus; ut tamen cum eis genus hominum secundarie accipiamus, quia, etsi disiuncti sumus a bono deo conditione nature, gratie

pointed out that Joachim and the anonymous biographer each speak about all three visions.) Likewise, Joachim claimed, it was necessary for him, just as for Moses, to make an exemplar of what he saw in order to reach others.¹⁴ The basic relationship of the two Testaments, Joachim tells us, was revealed in an image of one tree growing out of the top of another and he understood also that he received a divine mandate to record this for teaching.

There has long been a general consensus among scholars that Joachim's early ideas evolved out of his understanding of the concordance of Scripture; for Joachim not only are there parallels in what has taken place within Scripture but also between what took place in the Bible and what occurred afterward in ecclesiastical history. In the *Enchiridion* Joachim explained that his early insight into the 'concordiarum sacramenta' was that concordance between the Old Testament and Christ as its head would also apply to Christ's body, the Church.¹⁵ For example, an early

tamen ipsius participatione coniuncti. Nunquam enim diceret euangelista scribens dominicam genealogiam: "Qui fuit Ade, qui fuit dei", nisi eundem primum hominem filium esse dei per adoptionem sentiret. In prima itaque cedro—de cuius medulla et ramorum uertice nata est arbor secunda, aut dubium quod similis eius—populus ille antiquus intelligendum est qui, sicut iam superius, diximus creatus est specialius ad ymaginem Patris, sicut et sequens populus ad ymaginem Filii. Si autem secundum illud quod ait dominus Moysi: "Vide ut omnia facias secundum exemplar quod ostensum est tibi in monte", non quasi ex similitudine fingenda est ueritas, sed magis, ueritate perspecta, propter eos qui tardioris sunt ingenii, similitudo significans adhibenda, talem nos cedri huius ymaginem assignare oportet, qualem eam pro dono gratie in montis uertice contemplati sumus, non quales in siluis montium consueuerunt inueniri.' Also *Liber concordie Noui ac Veteris Testamenti* (Venice, 1519; repr. Frankfurt a. M., 1964), fo. 19r. As can be seen, Joachim's comment about his Mosaic vision comes in his discussion of the relationship of the two trees/two testaments, the topic of the chapter. Because this part of Book Two of the *Concordia* was written after his later visions, there is one mention at the very beginning of this chapter of a third tree that grows from these two. The chapter, however, treats only of the two trees and Joachim's mention of his Mosaic vision is immediately related to the two trees/two testaments discussion. See also Marjorie Reeves and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae of Joachim of Fiore* (Oxford, 1972), pp. 32–3.

For Joachim's tree imagery also see *Abbot Joachim of Fiore: Liber de Concordia Noui ac Veteris Testamenti*, pp. xxviii–xxxv and 107–12, 145–84.

¹⁴ Ibid., pp. 145–6, 'Si autem secundum illud quod ait dominus Moysi: "Vide ut omnia facias secundum exemplar quod ostensum est tibi in monte", non quasi ex similitudine fingenda est ueritas, sed magis, ueritate perspecta, propter eos qui tardioris sunt ingenii, similitudo significans adhibenda, talem nos cedri huius ymaginem assignare oportet, qualem eam pro dono gratie in montis uertice contemplati sumus, non quales in siluis montium consueuerunt inueniri.'

¹⁵ Joachim of Fiore, *Enchiridion super Apocalypsim*, ed. E. Burger (Toronto, 1986), pp. 47–8, 'Sed quia tempus adhuc parumper distat, ut ille intellectus qui perfecte erit in Spiritu assignari queat, magisque nobis incumbit assignare ea quae in statu secundo completa sunt,

hallmark of the abbot's thought¹⁶ is the matching of the persecutions of the Jews with the persecutions of the Church that had already occurred, along with some parallels still to be fulfilled. What is considered Joachim's earliest tract, the *Expositio de prophetia ignota* (1184), is held as an example of this approach since it contains such a concordance parallel but no mention of his famous three *status*.¹⁷

No writing of Joachim, however, has been verified as coming from the period before 1184, before the Easter and Pentecost revelations mentioned above, for us to be able to evaluate the earliest stage of Joachim's intellectual development. The survival of a major work from his early period is unlikely because the anonymous biographer noted that in this period Joachim did not violate Cistercian norms about writing, i.e., Abbot Joachim knew he needed permission of the General Chapter to produce a book.¹⁸ When the biographer described Joachim's exegetical activity what he has described is Joachim instructing, teaching, and speaking to his

respondentia operibus testimonii prioris, sicut in opere *Concordiae*, quantum Deus donavit, ostendimus, operae pretium credidi ea ipsa quae consonare veteribus simplici assertione monstravimus, pro eo scilicet quod historiae quas ecclesiasticas dicimus, minus authenticæ judicantur, ex libro Apocalypsis qui tantæ est auctoritatis ostendere, ut tanto securius illi operi fidem accommodare possimus, quanto concordiam rerum et temporum quæ in eo præstante Domino claruisse cognoscitur, nequaquam sensus hominis adinvenit et protulit sed is qui in utroque testimonio loquitur Spiritus edidit prophetiæ.

Denique et ego cum librum hunc lectitare coepissem, et adhuc concordiarum sacramenta nescirem, quo illuc impetu a primo ductus sim nescio, Deus scit. Unde scio quod nequaquam historiarum peritia ad concordiae notitiam perductus sum, sed sola præteritorum operum, hoc est, testimonii veteris comparatione pulsatus, credens discordare non posse in corpore quod in capite concors inveni, nec otiosum fore in reliquis sanctis quod in patriarchis et apostolis concordare perpendi, dedi operam in hoc ipso, ut quantum Deus mihi concederet testimoniorum concordiam compilarem, sed an scrupulosis mentibus satisfecerim nescio.

¹⁶ See Bernard McGinn, *Visions of the End* (New York, 1979), p. 315, n. 33, where he makes this observation in reference to Joachim's *Expositio de prophetia ignota*.

¹⁷ McGinn, *The Calabrian Abbot*, pp. 22–4, and 'Joachim and the Sibyl', *Cîteaux*, 24 (1973), pp. 97–138.

¹⁸ Grundmann, 'Zur Biographie Joachims von Fiore und Rainers von Ponza', p. 346, '... reverens tamen zelum ordinis, in quo stabat, quia non erat ei licitum scribere sine licentia Capituli generalis'. See also *ibid.*, pp. 307–8, and J.-M. Canivez, *Statuta capitulorum generalium Ordinis Cisterciensis*, 1 (Louvain, 1933), p. 26, "Si liceat alicui novos libros dictare." Nulli liceat abbati, nec monacho, nec novitio, libros facere, nisi forte cuiquam in generali capitulo concessum fuerit.' As I discussed in chapter two of my book, *Joachim of Fiore and Monastic Reform* (New York, 1990), the anonymous biographer was concerned to show that Joachim followed ecclesiastical regulations consistently, and in this case St Paul's admonition (I Cor. 14. 39–40), 'And so, my dear brothers, by all means be ambitious to prophesy . . . but let everything be done with propriety and in order', carried the watchword.

A New Writing of Joachim of Fiore

monks, as any good abbot, according to Benedict's *Rule*.¹⁹ What is significant, for us, is that the anonymous biographer reported that Joachim did comment on Scripture, instructed his monks, according to the special understanding given to him. Consequently, it is plausible that all that might survive from this period is not any major tract, but, possibly, a short instructional piece or notes²⁰ that record Joachim's commentary. If such a short piece is found, according to what I have outlined, it would be likely to draw on Joachim's principle of concordance that parallels such events as the suffering of the Jews and the persecutions of the Church, employ the basic tree imagery described above, and betray no indication of a third age of the Holy Spirit, new orders, Joachim's disapproval of the Cistercians—any later concepts developed with or after his Easter and Pentecost revelations. I have found a text that fits these criteria.

This discovery has come in a roundabout way. In 1990 Kurt-Victor Selge edited Joachim's *Praephatio sive Prologus super Apocalypsim*, dated to 1188–92. He used six manuscripts for this edition; there are three additional manuscript copies of this text: Rein, 61, 146v–152v, Valenciennes, Bibl. mun., 516, 162v–165v, and Zwettl, 326, 3r–10r.²¹ Rein and Valenciennes are the same as Selge's edition, except that the Valenciennes manuscript contains only the second half of Selge's text. The manuscript from the Cistercian monastery of Zwettl is different.²² It contains another section that amounts to a separate text embedded within a text identical to Selge's edited *Praefatio*. This text breaks the flow of the *Praefatio* commentary and was apparently copied by mistake within the body of the *Praefatio*. Also, at the end of this manuscript copy of the *Praefatio* from Zwettl is a fragment, Joachim's exegesis of Rev. 6. 6, that is related to his

¹⁹ See *Benedicti regula*, ed. R. Hanslik, *Corpus scriptorum ecclesiasticorum latinorum*, 75 (Vienna, 1977), p. 23, '... ut capacibus discipulis mandata domini uerbis proponere ...'.

²⁰ Joachim's sermons and short instructional pieces were not only not itemized in his corpus to be submitted to the Pope, but even today remain incompletely catalogued.

²¹ See F. Stegmüller, *Repertorium biblicum medii aevi*, 3 (Madrid, 1951), p. 226. There is a real need to publish a 'definitive' list of the manuscripts of Joachim of Fiore (and Pseudo-Joachim); one manuscript text, not recorded before, that I wish to note here is Joachim's *De septem sigillis* in Bruges, Stedelijke Openbare Bibl., MS 86, fos 100r–101r. See the edition of this work in Marjorie Reeves and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich, 'The seven seals in the writings of Joachim of Fiore', *Recherches de théologie ancienne et médiévale*, 21 (1954), pp. 239–47.

²² There is a short description of MS 326 in Stephan Rössler, 'Verzeichniss der Handschriften der Bibliothek des Stiftes Zwettl' in *Xenia Bernardina*, pt 2, vol. 1, *Die Handschriften-Verzeichnisse der Cistercienser-Stifte* (Vienna, 1891), p. 413, but no mention of Joachim of Fiore as the author of the *Praefatio*, which Rössler calls the *Explanatio libri Apocalypsis*, and no notice of this additional new text or the fragment on Rev. 6. 6. He dates Zwettl, MS 326 as 'XII u. XIII Jahr'.

commentaries on the same verse in the *Expositio in Apocalypsim* and the *Concordia*,²³ but is different from them. For some reason this Zwettl manuscript, dated to the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, contains these additional short texts. For us the significant text is the one embedded within the text of the *Praefatio*,²⁴ extending for three and one-half columns from fos 8v–9v. It contains an explanation of the relationship of the two Testaments similar to but more primitive than that found in Joachim's 'Tree of Two Advents' in his *Liber figurarum*.²⁵ One-half of the text uses the tree imagery explicitly; the second relates the various persecutions of the Jews to those of the Church. This text is a new version of what has been called the *Epistola subsequentium figurarum*. There are only three other manuscripts of this text extant: two in Paris, Bibl. Nat., Lat. 11864 and 3595, and one in Rome, Vat. Lat. 3822.²⁶ Using Leone Tondelli's edition and notes to compare the Paris manuscripts with the Vatican manuscript, one can see that the Vatican manuscript has additional material, such as an updating of the end to 1290, that comes from Joachim's followers; the Paris manuscripts, however, reflect concepts found in Joachim's writings.²⁷ The script of the *Epistola* in Paris, Bibl. Nat., Lat. 11864 has been dated to the first decade of the thirteenth century and the text of the *Epistola* (without this title, as is the case also of Zwettl, 326) is found here with only Joachim's genuine writings.²⁸ Leone

²³ Abbot Joachim of Fiore: *Liber de Concordia Noui ac Veteris Testamenti*, p. 295 and Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, fo. 115r–v. I am examining this fragment in the light of Joachim's condemned Trinitarian ideas.

²⁴ A comparison between Selge's edition and the Zwettl text shows that they are extremely close; where there are variants, in as much as I have been able to pursue this aspect of research now, the wording in Zwettl seems to make more sense, i.e., following standards of the internal logic of the text, scriptural reference or Joachim's choice of language in his other writings.

²⁵ See tavola II in Leone Tondelli, Marjorie Reeves, and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich, *Il Libro delle figure dell'abate Gioachino da Fiore*, 2 (Turin, 1953) and Reeves and Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae of Joachim of Fiore*, pp. 153–9.

²⁶ Marjorie Reeves, *The Influence of Prophecy in the Later Middle Ages* (Oxford, 1969), p. 518; Paris, Bibl. Nat., MS Lat. 11864, fos 151v–152v; Paris, Bibl. Nat., MS Lat. 3595, fos 28r–29r; and Rome, MS Vat. Lat. 3822, fos 3v–4r.

²⁷ The text, in its later version, has been edited by Jeanne Bignami-Odier, 'Notes sur deux manuscrits de la bibliothèque du Vatican contenant des traités inédits de Joachim de Fiore', *Mélanges d'archéologie et d'histoire*, 54 (1937), pp. 224–6. See Leone Tondelli, *Il Libro delle figure dell'abate Gioachino da Fiore*, 1 (Turin, 1953), pp. 41–3; Tondelli's footnotes show variants found in the Paris manuscript versions that reflect an earlier version than the Vatican text.

²⁸ Reeves and Hirsch-Reich, 'The Figurae of Joachim of Fiore: genuine and spurious collections', *Mediaeval and Renaissance Studies*, 3 (1954), p. 198; Morton Bloomfield and Marjorie Reeves, 'The penetration of Joachimism into Northern Europe', *Joachim of Fiore in Christian Thought*, ed. D. West, 1 (New York, 1975), p. 116 n. 40a.

A New Writing of Joachim of Fiore

Tondelli accepted the Paris version as a genuine work of Joachim. Marjorie Reeves and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich rejected the *Epistola* as genuine because, they asserted, apart from background in his main writings, Joachim did not explain his *figurae* separately from the drawings. And in relation to the tree the *Epistola* most closely describes, in the *Liber figurarum* there are differences—such as the term ‘Christus iudex’ not found in the *Liber figurarum*.²⁹ Reeves and Hirsch-Reich give the impression that the text, as presented in the Paris manuscripts, contains Joachim’s authentic thought, but not as found exactly in the *Liber figurarum*. Their objections to its genuineness fall away if one sees the *Epistola* as a record of Joachim’s thought not from the end of his career but from the beginning.

The text manifestly contains Joachim’s language, his concordance parallels, and his unique division of the generations of the Old and New Testaments. Scholarly effort in the past has been to try to relate the text of the *Epistola subsequentium figurarum* to Joachim’s very mature writings and the *figurae* which represent the summary of his work. The *Epistola* is intriguing because there is no third age of the Spirit, no future orders, no disapproval of the Cistercians. It has a basic concordance of the Old and New Testaments in the image of one tree growing out of another. The early examples of this work carry no title and the style is that of instructional notes, as Reeves and Hirsch-Reich point out,³⁰ so it would be better to refer to it simply as an instructional writing rather than as an *epistola*.

The text explains Joachim’s concordance in an elemental way: the entire span of time from the birth of Christ to the end is to be forty-two generations of thirty years each. At one point in this text the generations are divided into one group of forty and another of two. The Antichrist and the end of time will come in the last two generations, in the final sixty years, according to our author. Hence, this text has all the characteristics of what we could imagine in a possible early text of Joachim. What made the Zwettl manuscript copy so arresting for me is that when the author explained this structure of generations, within the tree imagery, he dated his own place in his chronology of generations. When he wrote about the future completion of forty generations from the birth of Christ he added that it is 1176 years [from the birth of Christ]. The Zwettl manuscript

²⁹ Reeves and Hirsch-Reich, ‘The *Figurae* of Joachim of Fiore’, pp. 178–82, and *The Figurae of Joachim of Fiore*, pp. 109–10 and 267–8; and Tondelli, *Il Libro delle figure*, p. 41. Herbert Grundmann, *Neue Forschungen über Joachim von Fiore* (Marburg, 1950), pp. 23–4, apparently did not know about the Paris manuscript from the first decade of the 1200s.

³⁰ Reeves and Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae of Joachim of Fiore*, p. 110.

reads: 'When therefore in this period from the birth of Christ forty generations are completed, it is 1176 years, only two generations remain to be completed, that is sixty years, that is two thirties in which whatever is said of the Antichrist and the end of time is to be fulfilled.'³¹

The date, 1176 years from the birth of Christ, MCLXXVI, is too distinctive to be a copyist's error for MCC, that is, a completed forty generations, 1200. Forgery or interpolation does not make any sense because the text has no specific target or patent motivation in this regard and such changes occur in Joachite texts usually only to update and in very obvious ways. (Also Joachite additions usually involve the new orders or the third age.) The only other possible significant miscopyings by a scribe that I could imagine in this case could be adding or dropping an X: therefore rendering the original date 1166 or 1186. If we assume now this is Joachim's writing, neither possibility works. If this is Joachim's text, by 1186, as we know well from his *De vita sancti Benedicti*, his writing was pre-occupied with the role of the Cistercian order, the symbol of St Benedict, the third age and the new order of monks that would lead to it.³² This text is much more basic or primitive. It has no third age,³³ no Cistercian reference, and no new order.³⁴ The *Praefatio* that envelops this text does show Joachim's later interests and insights.³⁵ In the other case a date of 1166 would put the text before Joachim's pilgrimage to the Holy Land and

³¹ Zwettl, MS 326, fo. 9r, 'Cum ergo nativitate Christi complete sint hoc temporum xl generationes, id est mclxxvi anni, non restant nisi due generationes complende, id est anni lx, id est duo terdenarii in quibus oportet impleri quicquid de antichristo dicitur et de consummatione seculi.'

³² See Stephen Wessley, 'Bonum est Benedicto mutare locum: The role of the "Life of Saint Benedict" in Joachim of Fiore's monastic reform', *Revue Bénédictine*, 90 (1980), pp. 314–28.

³³ There is no mention of a period of earthly bliss and Joachim lists different interpretations of Daniel's 45 days; this period of bliss is described as short in Joachim's *De ultimis tribulationibus*, ed. E. R. Daniel, 'Abbot Joachim of Fiore: The *De ultimis tribulationibus*', in *Prophecy and Millenarianism*, ed. A. Williams (Harlow, 1980), p. 183: '... ad istam modicam et breuem pacem'.

³⁴ There is an ambiguous 5/7 numerical relationship here in Zwettl, MS 326, fo. 9v. But in this text one finds no indication of Joachim's subsequent use of this sequence, as for example, when he later indicated the direction of future spiritual development in the inheritor of monastic reform.

³⁵ See Kurt-Victor Selge's description in his 'Eine Einführung Joachims von Fiore in die Johannesapokalypse', p. 100: 'Die Theorie der drei trinitarischen "Status" in Ergänzung der alten Lehre von den sechs Weltaltern und der jüngeren Lehre von den sieben Zeiten des sechsten Weltalters liegt fertig vor, ebenso die hermeneutische Theorie von der Concordia des Alten und Neuen Testaments und der sich aus ihr in Anwendung auf die Zeit der Kirche ergebenden spiritualis intelligentia.' Also compare the wording in *ibid.*, p. 104, for the sixth age: 'quinta in sacratissimi mundi salvatoris adventu, sexta ab eodem incepta', to Zwettl, MS 326, fo. 9r, 'sexta in iudice'.

therefore before any of his spiritual discoveries.³⁶ The date in this text, 1176, fits exactly the anonymous biographer's description of Joachim's activity. Elected abbot shortly before 1177, Joachim was hard at work on his commentaries of Scripture, according to his biographer, because he did not wish to neglect the grace he received in the understanding of Scripture given to him.

Other variants in Zwettl, 326 also pull the content of the text to Joachim's early period and enable the text not only to make more sense,³⁷ but even provide confirmation of what scholars had suggested might have been Joachim's debt to earlier exegetes. Reading this text as Joachim's own writing and accepting its accuracy opens new vistas. For example, one sentence in Zwettl, 326 concerning Daniel's forty-five days calls for particularly close attention. In his edition of the *Epistola*, Tondelli, working with two choices from his manuscripts, XII days and XLV days, chose neither and corrected the phrase concerning the days of Daniel to read 'XLII days in Daniel' to fit Joachim's famous numerology.³⁸ But there are no forty-two days in Daniel, only forty-two months according to Joachim.³⁹ There are *forty-five* days in Daniel following St Jerome's accounting for the discrepancy between Daniel's 1,290 and 1,335 days.⁴⁰ This idea of a forty-five-day period found in Jerome's writing received much discussion in medieval commentaries.⁴¹ An understanding that the

³⁶ Grundmann, 'Zur Biographie Joachims von Fiore und Rainers von Ponza', p. 298: 'Demnach wäre Joachim 1166/67 nach dem Tod König Wilhelms I. in der Kanzlei zu Palermo tätig gewesen und danach ins Heilige Land gegangen . . .'

³⁷ Only a publication comparing the manuscripts, with some commentary, can make this clear (I will prepare such a study and edition). Joachim's idiosyncrasy can be seen in part by one calculation of generations: two groups of sixty-three arrived at by counting the latter part of the Old Testament twice. See Reeves and Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae of Joachim of Fiore*, p. 9, and also p. 6: 'Now he plunges into intricate calculations of generations from which he constructs a framework which is constantly used hereafter: the generations are grouped in series of twenty-one in such a way that the Dispensation of the Old Testament is reckoned as 21 + 21 + 21, while that of the New (which, beginning with Ozias, overlaps the Old by twenty-one generations) will likewise endure for sixty-three generations, and beyond, to the *consummatio seculi*.' See Zwettl, MS 326, fo. 9r, where the two groups of generations are arranged to number sixty-three each. This is done as noted by an overlapping, i.e., by computing the beginning of the New Testament with Isaiah and Ozias. Also, as is typical of Joachim, in this text we see some hesitancy in pronouncing when the end will occur.

³⁸ Tondelli, *Il Libro delle figure*, p. 42.

³⁹ Herbert Grundmann, *Studien über Joachim von Floris* (Leipzig, 1927), p. 52.

⁴⁰ Robert Lerner, 'Refreshment of the Saints: the time after Antichrist as a station for earthly progress in medieval thought', *Traditio*, 32 (1976), pp. 102–3.

⁴¹ Zwettl, MS 326, fo. 9r; the sequence of day, month, year, age in the text does not seem to refer to specific earlier controversies about the length of time, especially if Lerner's 'Refreshment of the Saints' is reasonably complete, but rather expresses the idea that it is unclear what

numbers are accurate in Zwettl, 326⁴² (which reinforces the notion of the integrity of the text), that is, that the reading XLV days in reference to Daniel is correct, opens up a whole new connection to Robert Lerner's noted thesis in his article, 'Refreshment of the Saints'. Lerner presented Daniel's forty-five days as a seminal concept for changes in medieval eschatological expectations and he thought it was probable that the tradition stemming from Jerome's concept had been a starting point for Joachim.⁴³ This now visible link to prior exegesis, envisioned as a probable starting point for Joachim, helps also to convince us of the text's validity as an early work of the abbot.

Convinced of the significance of the date in the Zwettl manuscript, I realized that the other three manuscripts on which Tondelli based his edition and critical notes and Reeves and Hirsch-Reich their observations must be checked carefully. And, though mentioned by no one else, Paris, Bibl. Nat., Lat. 11864 also has the date 1176.⁴⁴ Hence, there are four manuscript copies of this text extant; one half of the total, the two manuscripts that are the earliest and that are found only with Joachim's genuine writings, contain the date 1176.

Using the date 1176 written in this text,⁴⁵ I find that the content fits

Daniel's forty-five days stand for. Joachim posits in this text that the learned have said that a month can stand for a day, so Daniel's forty-five days could be forty-five months, etc., not that others have proposed this explanation for the meaning of Daniel.

⁴² Zwettl, MS 326, fo. 9r, 'Quod tempus a Daniele dicitur xlv videlicet dierum.'

⁴³ Lerner, 'Refreshment of the Saints', pp. 97–114 and 117. See also Marjorie Reeves, 'How original was Joachim of Fiore's theology of history?', *Storia e messaggio in Gioacchino da Fiore, Atti del I Congresso internazionale di studi gioachimiti* (S. Giovanni in Fiore, 1980), pp. 25–41. This period of forty-five days, consonant with the earlier traditions, is a time of penance and conversion to one faith. Careful attention should be given also to the seven ages in this text to appreciate how Joachim changed them in his mature writings. With the sixth age to be that of Christ the Judge, the seventh 'in quiete animarum' in Zwettl, MS 326, fo. 9r, takes on a heavenly dimension. The seventh age is not like the description in Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, fos 209v–210r. Again, this helps confirm the early period of the text.

⁴⁴ Paris, Bibl. Nat., MS Lat. 11864, fo. 152v.

⁴⁵ Pietro De Leo, 'Una nuova opera di Gioacchino da Fiore? Il *Super Cantica Canticorum* in un codice cosentino del XII secolo', *L'Età dello Spirito e la fine dei tempi in Gioacchino da Fiore e nel Gioachimismo medievale, Atti del II Congresso internazionale di studi gioachimiti* (S. Giovanni in Fiore, 1986), pp. 435–88, and *Gioacchino da Fiore* (Soveria Mannelli, 1988), pp. 58, 129, has proposed that a particular anonymous commentary on the Song of Songs is an early work of Joachim from the last quarter of the twelfth century. Kurt-Victor Selge, 'L'origine delle opere di Gioacchino da Fiore', pp. 91–2, n. 16, thinks that the content of De Leo's text does not allow 'alcuna conclusione sulla paternità di Gioacchino...'. De Leo, 'Una nuova opera', p. 440, considers the Codex Cusentinus not an 'apografo, bensì di uno scritto originale'. If one accepts Fabio Troncarelli's conclusions in 'Un codice con note autografe di Gioacchino da Fiore', *Scriptorium*, 43 (1989), pp. 3–34, there is a discrepancy between the script of the two

A New Writing of Joachim of Fiore

perfectly to the early period of Joachim's career and am convinced that the text of the so-called *Epistola* as found in Zwettl, 326⁴⁶ and Paris, Bibl. Nat., Lat. 11864 should be given further consideration as evidence of Joachim's first period of exegetical activity.

texts. Both cannot be in Joachim's hand. An examination of the shape of the letter 'd' in the manuscripts Troncarelli and De Leo examined shows me they were written by two different hands. The notes that Troncarelli ascribes to Joachim in Rome, Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, MS Barb. Lat. 627, may be early, but they have been able to be dated only in a general way.

⁴⁶ Zwettl, MS 326 has the best readings and seems closest to the original.